



Sitting, leaning on a laundry basket or stool Rest your body in this position, allowing yourself to build up your strength for the next wave of contractions.



Straddling a chair This will help open your pelvis while allowing you a rest so that you can save energy to deal with the next contraction.



Kneeling, partner support Gain comfort and physical support by kneeling on a bed and embracing your partner.



Standing, leaning forward on partner This position can make you feel close to each other and help you to relax. Your partner can support your body weight.



Side lying Lying on your right or left side can help soothe the pain and help alter your baby's position slightly if your baby is lying back to back.



Semi-prone, fetal back toward the ceiling If you know that your baby is facing right with its back against yours, you can lie on your left side for short periods. Gravity may pull the baby into a more comfortable position.

Q What are the benefits of laboring in water, and are there risks?

Women who labor in water make fewer requests for pain relief. It's thought that this has to do with the calming effect of being in water, because the measured amplitude (intensity) of contractions in fact remains the same in and out of the water. Women who labor in water also find it easier to change position since they are supported by the buoyancy of the water, and are less likely to need an episiotomy. There are no risks that specifically relate to going through your labor in water. Your doctor can monitor the baby's heart rate using a waterproof handheld heart monitor to make sure your baby shows no signs of distress, and will take appropriate action if she does.

Q When should I get into my birthing pool?

Some experts believe that being in water during the early stages of labor can slow contractions and prolong labor. They advocate getting into the water only once you are 7 cm dilated. Others believe that being in water eases pain and promotes relaxation, improving labor. If you are using a pool at a hospital or birthing center, you will need to follow their protocol. At home, you can decide when to get in and out of the pool. Always make sure the water temperature is never over 99.5°F (37.5°C).

Q I want to lie on a bed, but will this make my labor more painful?

Lying down pushes the lower part of your spine against the baby's head. The added pressure when the baby tries to move past this part of your back and deeper into your pelvis can make labor more painful. Lying on your back also narrows the space that you have for your pelvic bones to separate to allow the baby through, which can increase the pain. Contractions when lying down can be more painful and less effective, lengthening your labor. If you need to lie down, don't lay flat on your back but on your left side. Lying down can be the position that is most useful for your doctor, because he or she can easily examine you. Your baby can be monitored if you are in a sitting position.